

Secure Our Borders!

WHILE YOU ENJOY this issue—filled with the latest in portable media players, and the other goodies that come with *Digit* each month, I would like you to spare a moment to consider the security of our country's borders.

The US has just erected a 'virtual' fence along a portion of its border with Mexico. The project cost \$20 million to complete, and consists of sensor towers and advanced mobile communications. The plan is to extend this 'virtual' fence to other parts of the border as well.

This is the future of defence technology. Why doesn't India embark on a similar project to secure its eastern and western borders?

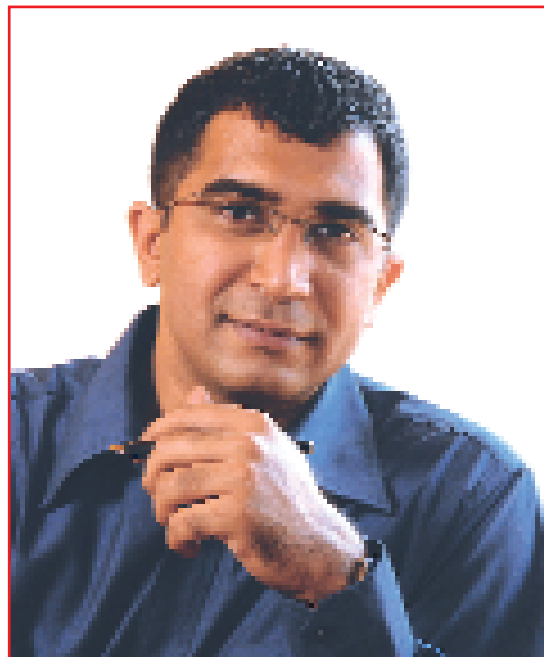
Because of its long and porous border, our country faces the problems of illegal immigration from the east and militant infiltration from the west. High-tech surveillance would certainly help solving these problems. Unmanned aerial vehicles and computer-controlled radar systems would go a long way in boosting security.

The question that might be asked is whether this technology can justify its costs. To answer that, India is already paying a heavy price for not being able to keep illegal immigration and infiltration in check. The benefits of securing our borders through technology would far outweigh the costs involved in such a project.

A team from India should visit the US installation and get a few tips from the American department of Homeland Security to understand how the high-tech system operates. Our government can then float a global tender to invite bids from major players—like Boeing in the US' case—to set up this virtual fence.

The reason I brought this up is because technology fundamentally changes almost every facet of a particular situation. Using technology lets you think outside the box, and then ask crucial questions on a particular issue that might never have been asked in the first place.

Remember, India is a prime target for terrorism, and to fight this global war on terror, it needs to beef up its technology arsenal first. Several strategists in



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the US are already welcoming that country's increased spend on security, going to the extent of predicting that a refurbished, high-tech Homeland Security could be the best thing to happen to Silicon Valley in years.

Will India be able to get its tech security act together? Being a global IT powerhouse, it is only a matter of time—according to my opinion—before policymakers chart out a tech roadmap to prepare our country against hostile alien attacks.

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